

CROWN OF THORNS



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A Crown of Thorns

A crown of thorns upon the Godhead-
The bramble tears within His brow.
The hammered spikes held up His body-
God's very Son hung disavowed.

The Triune God now separated-
Forsaken hung upon a cross.
Degraded, beaten- marred and tarnished.
A kingly vesture- clothed in dross.

A Man of sorrows- bourn to shame,
Unblemished lamb cruelly admonished.
Delivered to a king for counsel
Almighty Counselor defamed.

A broken body- upright spirit;
The Wonderful grotesque became.
The God incarnate dwelt among us-
Our mortal souls defied His reign.

Mankind's rebellious ambitions,
Were brought upon His life to bear,
And with our devious fruitions-
Now of His life had He despaired.

God hung upon the cross at Calvary.
He hung between our very midst-
Half raised to heav'n- bound on earth.
Both God and Man rejected Him.

He took the heavy load upon Him,
He suffered all our sin in full,
Came down from heaven us to pardon-
Crimson and Scarlet- white as wool.

The deed upon the cross now finished,
Transgressions' balance paid in full.
His lot was cast among transgressors.
His grace abounding bountiful.

For He was well acquainted with them,
Who suffered long in silent grief.

He carries all their loads upon Him.
And helped them in their unbelief.

A smoking flax He shall not muffle.
A broken reed He shall not break.
The sick he did forbear to strengthen.
Not one lost sheep did He forsake.

It's not about a joyful ending-
Though joyful endings may once come.
This suffering showed heart and motive.
Our human state to overcome.

Anger and pride- all our afflictions,
We strive- to like our Saviour bear.
A life of victory is the struggle-
And only His do we declare.

A crown of thorns upon the Godhead-
The bramble tears within His brow.
The hammered spikes held up His body-
God's very Son hung disavowed.

True Beauty

It's funny that at the end of the day, life is itself the biggest drama- the strangest and most convoluted novel ever written- wherein lie chaos and comfort, blood spilled to save, and yet more to be wasted. A novel where you find the profoundest meaning and purpose, and yet also, the deepest pits of idleness- hollowness, frivolity, and emptiness. We live in a novel where our lives are but a jot upon a single page of thousands, and yet altogether, our conglomerate jots write a word- a phrase- perhaps a sentence, which describes as a whole what effect we had upon this tiny speck floating in the immeasurable vastness of both time and space. No matter how great we seem in our current state, we are nothing, not only compared to the vastness of space and time, but also compared to the One who has lasted for eternities past and will last for many more in the future, or better yet- One who exists within both eternities past and eternities yet to come at the same time because He transcends them.

No matter how hard we try to be relevant, we are but traces left in the snow which will either melt or be swept away with the wind of time, if not luckily preserved with or covered by the snowfall of history. And yet, for some reason we are of consequence and seem to have purpose in this drama- this novel, where the Author steps into its very pages in order to save it from its own demise, and by doing so, He suffers the wrath of His very own creation. Being above and beyond His masterpiece, He was misunderstood, and sentenced to die, in order that we might live and thus obtain access to a relationship with Him. All this, to write a novel in which He allows His creation to experience just a sliver of the grandeur and the splendor that He Himself experiences- and all this at His very Own expense.

He knew that in writing such a novel He would Himself be burdened with redeeming it with the deepest cost- a part (and yet the wholeness) of His own life incarnated within His creation. It's astounding, to say the least, and leaves the feeling of inadequacy- but in a good kind of way. It provides peace and serenity in knowing that our finite insignificance is cherished by the Infinite and the One of utmost significance. Our lives- whether grand or trivial are of utmost importance to the Creator- and that in itself provides the meaning and context to wake up every day and have joy. Joy- that in this vast novel, even the smallest things are accounted for by the Author. Life, though seemingly insignificant in the grand scale of existence, is full of incomprehensible value in the eyes of the Author, and that alone is a concept to revel in. There is meaning, there is value, and there is joy in life as a whole- if only we were to see it from the eyes of the Author and Creator of it.

Gifts Abounding

God is exceedingly good at giving gifts. In the very beginning He gave us the gift of life itself- that we might be able to explore, create and enjoy everything that is around us, and correspondingly- praise and thank Him through both the gifts of worship and direct fellowship with Him which He had given us from the beginning.

Paired along with this gift of life, He thought it best to give us the gift of choice- so that in our free will we might choose to truly love Him, because true love cannot (within our given means) exist if there wasn't ever the opportunity to choose it, otherwise, it wouldn't really have been true love, but rather an imposed choice or inflicted emotion.

Sadly, whenever there is an opportunity to choose right, there is likewise a chance that we might choose wrong (or at least that is how God willed it to be at this present time), and in consequence of choosing wrong, there spawns the origin of pain- another gift that we can either use to learn and grow by gaining a greater trust in God, or the which we can use to our own demise through allowing ourselves to grow spiteful or skeptical.

When Adam and Eve chose a path that through its coming to pass had undone the gift of direct fellowship with God, and when the prior mentioned gift of pain began to seem too much to bear for the both of them- God gave to them the gift of hope, a gift that relied upon God's own faithful character and not upon men's frail and flailing hearts. This gift of hope came packaged in a promise, that one day- God Himself would provide a means by the which there would but come redemption, and through that hope, He generously bestowed to us the gift of faith, a direct consequence of His sovereign grace. This faith existed both in times past and to the present day, the culmination of which is found in God's greatest gift yet- His very Son.

By His gift of grace He bestowed upon us His gift of love- a love that dwelt incarnate in His very Son (a love which is His very self for "God is love"), and that both was and is poured upon our hearts through the gift of His Holy Spirit which dwells this day within us. This same Spirit has restored our direct fellowship with God almighty (though differing in form of that which was in Eden, but still a mystery nonetheless.)

And as the final (though unfathomable) gift, He promised us the gift of heaven and eternal life where no pain and sorrow can exist, and where we will dwell in God's glory, if- we be faithful to Him and trust in His Son for our redemption.

Truly, nearly everything we have in life, and life itself in one form or another is a gift from God Himself. We just don't seem to have the eyes to see things for what they really are.

Truth Deferred

“What is truth” the question resounded and reverberated across the empty hall. It echoed off the pillars in such a manner so as to ask the questioner himself whether he truly knew the answer to his own appeal. An old saying goes something along the lines of “In every joke there is a subtle slither of truth.” Though his comment was made in sheer jest (or sarcasm), it probed at a much deeper, realer question than anyone could have ever imagined. A question buried deep within his very heart.

One could think that he said those words as if to only hear himself say them. As if saying them would somehow justify his choice. As if, his choice now justified was free of consequences. Pontius Pilate stared aimlessly into the distance. His eyes were blank, his mind was wholly somewhere else.

Thoughts race to and thro inside his head. Important decisions are never to be made in haste, but when revolt lies rampant right outside your doorway... What is a man to do in such state? “What is the worth of one soul when the stability of an empire is at stake?” could have easily crossed his mind, or maybe, “What is the value of truth when thousands of lives are hanging in the balance?” Perhaps our man was of a baser sort and thought: “What is truth, when pride and reputation are at risk?” It is not our place to judge his thoughts, though his actions are fair game. This we know for sure- mob rule prevented justice. Though this all lay divinely within God’s very plans, the ends could never justify the means.

Our man paces back and forth in contemplation, “What part have I in customs and traditions? What role play I in rituals and religions? Leave it to the people to decide,” and so good judgement is deferred. Truth, now curbed, lies sulking in the dust. Our man gives in to evil thrust and in depleted moral state decides to wash his hands of human lusts and hate and lets the mob-ruled crowd now have its final say in nailing the Messiah up to hang.

Did he not know that truth deferred sets precedent to ruin? Did he not care that God’s own Son stood in his midst? Or- did his thirst for acceptance and reputation but seal the final fate of God’s Beloved? A final plea came from his wife- “What can I do? My hands are tied,” his answer came in gentle sigh.

He sits upon his royal throne, the crisis now averted. Shame guilts his discomposed perplexed complexion, and fin’lly he decrees, “Let it be written thus, the one and only ‘King of Jews.’” The riotous religious leaders rage against his noble notions, and yet, he, not dissuaded, states, “What I have written, I have written,” acknowledging God’s only Son.

The above was written in a style of historical fiction. It probes at certain thoughts that Pontius Pilate’s might have had concerning the crucifixion of Christ, and so, it should not be taken as historical fact. I wanted to show that we often villainize people when we are no better ourselves. We’re all human, and we all face difficult decisions. Many “evil” or “villainous” characters in the Bible are more similar to us than we would like to think- and being able to realize that can give us wisdom and provide opportunities for personal growth and reflection.

Of Love

Behold, the hands of time have drawn away the veils. They have pulled back the stage curtains and have revealed who we really are, and what truly lies within our hearts. They have washed away- they have worn off the maquillage- the façade that we have so carefully pieced together to mask our true complexion. They have revealed in some the “Wizard of Oz,” and yet in others, they have drawn diamonds as from out of coal.

The hardened heart, though it seem perfectly normal for a while, shall grow more and more callous, and because patience shall have her perfect work, it will push some to finally shatter and show what truly lies within. Yet, in others, it will reveal how truly beautiful they are by refining out the impurities by fire.

Like a river, time has washed away the riverbanks to reveal either soft and spineless soil, or strong and solid stone, and sadly- oftentimes, we are left heart-broken by that which has drifted away with the current.

These very hands of time have revealed both that which lay within the heart of Evil and that which lay within the heart of Christ. These very hands have in time past have torn away the flesh of man and have revealed what lies within his heart, whether love or hatred pumps through its very veins. In the case of Christ, we’ve seen the love pour out within the blood beneath the cross. But what of the hearts of those who hung Him there? Though their hearts lay hidden behind flesh and clothing, out of them poured out more violently both vile hatred and bitter bloodlust for injustice. Both hearts were tested, and both tried true to reveal true convictions and true commitments- whether they would love themselves or others when compelled to choose.

It’s clear that at the end of the day, nearly every one of those hearts ended up loving “self” more. But had they only known what love truly was? Oh, had they but realized that love of self is truly the greatest way to hate oneself. Had they only had eyes to see the love that gave rather than the one that spitefully consumed and devoured all that stood in its way.

They saw with their eyes, and yet were blinded by their hatred. They heard with their ears, and yet they chose to listen to their hearts instead- those hearts so full of vile passions and distasteful dreams, insipidly boiling out from within. They hung with their very hands, and yet, they were truly hanging themselves upon the crosses of self-conceit and self-consumption- the pride of life. A consumption that thrived on the emptiness within, and a conceit that deceitfully convinced its very host to do what served its own purposes best.

Oh, but had we learned from our mistakes? For, was it not us- who hung Him there? Was it not our own hands that did this, and did not time unveil what lay hidden in our very own hearts? Do not the sins of man today hang upon that cross with Christ back then? Did time not show the hate and desperation that lay within us? It was our bloodlust- our demise that forced Him to hang! We hung him there in our own place. Our sins convicted us, and yet we punished Him. It was our own self-consuming nature that had consumed His very life. It was that same nature that left Christ no

other choice, but to fill the unsatiable void, with something- the saturation of which could not be depleted. That something was a someone- and that someone was His very own incarnate Self.

His very Self was the fullness and the ecstasy of God, which now dwells in the void of our past self-consumption that used to be. It filled the chasm within our soul and bridged the gap to make us whole. It sewed up with itself the tears that burst about the seams. It now gives us what we could never have hoped for- love. For God is love, and we could not have had Him lest He gave Himself free willingly into our hands- and look! Just- look at what we have done to Him! Oh- Our very hands are covered in His blood. A blood mingled with our sins....

And with that blood, man finally received what he could not have of himself- forgiveness, and the love that poured out with it.

That blood which should have condemned us now cleanses us of our sins, but through the spilling of it, the true nature of man was revealed. Though we would desire to hide this nature, if we don't have Christ living within us daily, then with time, I believe we will grow more irritable, more self-centered, and more sinful than we ourselves can even imagine. If it's fake, it won't last. If it's real, it'll only grow brighter and purer day by day. Think about it. Pray about it. Don't let life draw you away from what's really important. Don't wait for time to tell everybody else what you already know. And if you know what truly lies inside your heart- repent. Not to someone or in front of everyone. Repent first before God. Repentance is between God and man- all others are just witnesses. Let go of the vile bitterness and hatred that lies within you and give it to the one Who came and suffered to redeem that hatred. If not- that hatred will grow, and consequences will follow. Don't let your life become a source of darkness. Let God's light shine in, and let that light illuminate the darkness in your soul. Don't succumb to the hatred. Let go. Break the chains. Remove the façade. Live- and live freely. Let God's love pour into and out of you. And when the hands of time draw back the veils- let there be love. Let there be life.

The Resolute of Elegance

What hopelessness is there in death!
Of endless peace and joy bereft*-
The human soul should now be cleft*,
In horror wrought with dissonance.

What sorrow lies beyond the grave,
A dreadful fate- to death a slave!
God through His very Son forgave
What should have been our recompence*.

What hope now stirs within the night,
The darkness yields to dawning light;
Corruption's force now shorn of might,
Before the Son claims impotence.

What mercy strides where fear once reigned,
Where terror once its rule maintained;
Death's shackles have become unchained,
Its power stripped of permanence.

What wonder stirs the trembling soul,
When grace assumes its sovereign role;
The curse no longer bears control,
Nor binds us to its consequence.

What unrelenting joy is this?
The heart now filled with endless bliss.
We've now accepted heaven's kiss
And grants us now benevolence!

What privilege is so refined,
To now be of a humbler mind,
And revel in the grand design,
Of wonder and magnificence.

And now to be of lowly state,
His suffering to emulate*,
And never cease or e'er abate*
To worship Him in reverence.

Until the hour that He returns,
And from our earthly role adjourns

Our life with all of its concerns
And gives us our inheritance.

Where everlasting peace abounds,
And heaven's chorus now resounds-
His glories, ever-most profound,
The resolute of elegance.

Bereft- deprived of or lacking.*

Cleft- split, divided, or partially divided into two.*

Dissonance- a tension or clash resulting from the combination of two disharmonious or unsuitable elements.*

Recompense- an equivalent or a return for something done.*

Beneficence- something good being shown or done to someone.*

Emulate- to try to be like (someone or something you admire.)*

Abate- to put an end to or reduce.*

Resolute- admirably purposeful, determined, and unwavering.*

Gentle Reminiscences

We eat, we drink- and then we hunger.
We build our homes to watch them crumble.
We marry, not knowing what tomorrow brings-
And listen lest we hear the toll that death's bell rings.

We cherish the embrace of friends and loved ones,
Then give chase, tow'rd dreams of victory and glory,
Yet from our grasp is torn our story-
And lose we hold of our ambitions, once grown old.

Is life so futile in its promise?
We laugh, we weep- sit still and cry.
We live- and then, at last, we die
Lift up thy gaze- believe, O doubting Thomas,
For life beyond the grave is nigh.

The longer I do live, the more convinced I grow,
God governs the affairs of men- of this I know.
And if a sparrow cannot fall upon the ground without His notice
Then who am I to ruminate* upon life's woe?

Though ignorance is bliss,
It is the poison of the devil.
You would but cease to disagree,
If ignorance upon death's cliffs would be-
A mist settled upon you.

So, do not stand, not knowing truth,
If you but seek it, you shall find it.
Repent, open your eyes and see-
Stand up, roll up your bed, be free,
When the solution is so simple, be ye sure,
That God's own answer is behind it.

Ruminate- To think deeply about something.*

Couplet four is an adaptation of a quote by Benjamin Franklin.

The last two lines of couplet six are a rewording of a quote by Albert Einstein.

Lead me

Lead me through the mighty raging waters¹.
Guide me by Your strong and loving hand².
Call me, like a fisher on the waters-
Call me, so that I might now catch men³.

Fight for me, like a strong and mighty warrior⁴.
Protect me with a firm and outstretched arm.
Heal me when I'm wounded in the battle⁵.
Shield me, when in danger or in harm⁶.

Pilot me through the long-forgotten wilderness
Which path to take I do not understand.
Guide me with a pillar of Your fire⁷,
That I might finally reach the promised land⁸.

Pull me out of this dismal swamp- this mire.
The murky clay doth cling unto my soul.
Wash me- clothe me in a new attire⁹,
Fill me with Your Spirit, make me whole¹⁰.

I seek You in a dry and weary desert,
Where there is no water to be found¹¹.
Find me in some cave where I have hidden-
Whisper, like an echo, in the wind¹².

Reveal what my soul is longing after.
Tell me why it lingers in dismay.
Forsooth, I do not know my cause of turmoil.
"Help me, give me peace," for this I pray.

Lead me, even though I sometimes falter,
Hold me in Your strong and loving hands.¹³
Hide me from the lion's ruthless slaughter¹⁴,
That I may faithfully before Your presence stand.

Draw me from this unrepentant nation,
Cleanse me so that I might be set apart¹⁵.
Take me from the middle of the desert,
Place me in the middle of Your heart.

Yes Lord- place me in the middle of Your presence,
That I might never from Your grace depart.

¹Psalm 93:4; ²Psalm 139:7-10; ³Matthew 4:19; ⁴Isaiah 42:13, Exodus 15:3;

⁵Psalm 147:3; ⁶Proverbs 30:5; ⁷Exodus 13:21; ⁸Hebrews 11:9-10, 13:14, Revelations 21:10; ⁹Ephesians 4:22-25, 6:14-18, Revelations 3:5;

¹⁰1 Thessalonians 5:23, Colossians 2:10; ¹¹Psalm 63:1; ¹²1 Kings 19:9-13;

¹³Isaiah 40:11; ¹⁴1 Peter 5:8-9; ¹⁵Isaiah 40:11.

Rekindling Ashes

I've been trying to rekindle the ashes,
Though there's nothing much left to be burned.
I've been trying to remember the answers
To the lessons I've already learned.

I've been trying to revisit the milestones,
Step by step by reliving my past.
I've been trying to go through the motions,
Though the time to move on has long passed.

I've been trying to collect all the pieces,
Of a membrane shattered by time.
I've been trying to unwrinkle the creases,
Set in stone and enveloped by grime.

Maybe memories were meant to be cherished,
Maybe new ones were meant to be made.
Maybe fires were meant to be started-
Not rekindled from ember's fair fade.

Though it's hard to move on, this I promise-
Through whatever awaits far ahead,
There is hope for a glistening fire,
And a season for everything set.

Maybe journeys were meant to be traveled,
Maybe new souls were meant to be saved.
Maybe it's time for me- to go somewhere else,
Where no path has ever been laid.

Might I go out and preach the Gospel,
To a people who never have heard
God's plan of enduring salvation
Revealed within His true Word.

Maybe life is still brimming with purpose,
Maybe hope is yet to be found-
And instead of umbering ashes
Maybe flames are meant to abound.

Let me now seek my purpose, not pleasure,
To discover the meaning of life,

To trust in the living Messiah,
And be free from all turmoil and strife.

Yes- maybe fires were meant to be started,
Not rekindled from ember's fair fade.

Utmost Humility

The utmost of humility,
The epitome of fate.
The God Who reigns forever
Brought down to lowly state.¹

The Lord of sovereign glory-
With crown of thorn now hangs!²
The ground is washed by crimson flow,
Of blood poured out His veins.

A lamb brought to the slaughter-
Afflicted and oppressed.³
A mix of blood and water
Pours 'neath His pier-ced chest.⁴

“As dogs they circle round Me,
And pierce My hands and feet.”⁵
“My God, My God- oh, tell Me why
Thou hast forsaken Me?”⁶

Then says He “It is finished,”⁷
And night usurps the day.⁸
The ground shakes fervently beneath
As saints rise from the grave.⁹

The veil within the temple,
Is finally torn in two.¹⁰
Instead, an Intercessor,
Now pleads for me and you.¹¹

Descended down from heaven,¹²
Ascended up from hell,¹³
His love shall know no measure,¹⁴
His grace no power quell.¹⁵

And lo, the crowds who mocked Him,
In sorrow stand ashamed.¹⁶
The soldiers underneath the cross,
Revere the One they maimed.¹⁷

“A truth,” said one who watched Him,
“This was the Son of God-

None other was to Him akin.¹⁷
The Gentile gave Him laud.¹⁸

Man of sorrows, bruised and maimed-¹⁹
This, the legacy He claimed.
Son of God a man ordained,²⁰
Beat relentlessly- profaned.¹⁹

Oh! What evidence of valor-
Oh! What triumph in defeat-²¹
When God of heaven comes to earth²²
To wash a sinner's feet.²³

What image of humility-
I think you would agree,
That God in all His glory,²⁴
Would die for you and me.

And what a joy belated,
Awaits all them ahead,
Who live believing on His name,
Alive shall be- not dead²⁵

In realms of heaven's glory,
On golden streets above,²⁶
We shall adore Him humbly
Who died to show us love.²⁷

What fullness of humility,
What epitome of fate.
That God would leave His glory-
To open heaven's gate.

¹Philippians 2:5-8, ²Mark 15:17-25, ³Isaiah 53:7, ⁴John 19:34,37 (something that can only happen if someone is clinically dead), ⁵Psalms 22:16 (foreshadowing of the crucifixion) ⁶Matthew 27:46, ⁷John 19:30, ⁸Luke 23:45, ⁹Matthew 27:51-53, ¹⁰Matthew 27:51, Luke 23:45, ¹¹Hebrews 7:25-27, Romans 8:34, ¹²John 6:38, ¹³1 Peter 3:19-20, Ephesians 4:9, Acts 2:24, Hosea 13:14 (the concept that Christ went all the way down to Hell between the crucifixion and resurrection and preached to some who had not yet had a chance to believe) ¹⁴Romans 8:37-39, ¹⁵John 1:16, 2 Corinthians 8:9, ¹⁶Luke 23:48, ¹⁷Matthew 27:54, Mark 15:39, Luke 23:47, ¹⁸Reference verses in 17, ¹⁹Isaiah 53:3-4, Mark 15:15-20, Matthew 27:29-31, ²⁰Philippians 2:5, Luke 1:35, Matthew 26:63-63, ²¹1 Corinthians 15:55, ²²Philippians 2:6-8, ²³John 13:1-17, ²⁴2 Corinthians 5:19,15, Philippians 2:6-8, ²⁵John 3:16, ²⁶Revelations 21:21, ²⁷Revelations 21:9-12.

Reconciled

When heaven's doors to earth were sealed,
And silence grasped the midnight sky
My heart toward heavenward appealed,
And shuddered in a broken cry.

"What shall I do to find an answer,
How will my soul escape dismay?"
A prayer- an emanated whisper-
To ask for guidance in the fray.

"Do not delay my blessed Saviour,
And answer Thou my gentlest cry.
My dearest Lord, be not a stranger,
I pray Thee: do not pass me by."¹

Undo my doubting disposition,
Untangle all my wretched mess.
'Renew my faith' is my petition,
My unrelenting fears suppress.

Your grace and mercy to adore,
This world and self-conceit abhor.
To rid me of my vain distress
Your will with mine to coalesce

To finally set my heart on fire
My mind to greater things aspire
In prayer to knock upon Your doors,
And always thirst and hunger more²

For life which freely flows from heaven³
For strength to shine in darkness midst⁴
The ever blackening and dire
Darkness that does now persist.⁵

To wield my sword and shield wisely⁶
Against the wickedness on high.⁷
Thy Word to utilize concisely-⁸
To raise Your banner to the sky-

To walk not in timidity
But in the power of Thy love.⁹

To conquer vain proclivity
With courage granted from above.

To stand within the hurricane
Of lustful passions and desires
To not be shackled by the chains
Of sins accruing in hellfire-

Oh Lord, for all these things I pray
Let not my spirit go astray
Let not my heart to go amiss
And stumble into hell's abyss.

Now let my mind become unstrewn
Untangled from its past desires
And let my soul become immune
To all of sin's most clinging briers.

Let that same soul in freedom dwell
Your presence- desolation quell.
And grant my heart abide in peace
Your tenderness- my yearning cease.

Allow my prayer to reach Your throne,
Give ear- ere turn my heart to stone."
And silence grasped the night again
A prayer was ended with "Amen."

Creaked heaven's doors- a whisper mild
"Your prayer is heard beloved child.
My blood was shed- though undefiled."
Pierced hands embraced me- reconciled.

¹A reference to "Pass me not oh gentle Savior"; ²Matthew 5:6, Isaiah 55:1-3;

³John 4:13-14; ⁴Matthew 5:13-14, 1 Thessalonians 5:5; ⁵Psalms 23:4;

⁶Ephesians 6:16-17, Hebrews 4:12; ⁷Ephesians 6:12; ⁸Ephesians 6:16, Hebrews 4:12; ⁹2 Timothy 1:7, Romans 8:15.

A Tree With Many Leave

A tree with many leaves,
No fruit upon its branches.

A tree with many leaves,
Being only good for planches*.

A tree with many boughs,
Only foliage to bear.

A tree with many boughs,
Leaves of vanity and care.

Standing tall and high and haughty,
It splits its wooden frame from weight.
Crooked, cracking, ever knotty,
About to shatter from its state.

Here comes the Keeper of the vineyard-
He looks upon the scraggly tree,
Decides to make the count'nance marred*
Now ever lovely- ever free.

The tree has been through quite a battle,
Did ever strive to make its own,
And though tow'rd pruning it held hatel*,
It realized how ill it'd grown.

With care and patience worked the Keeper,
The tree now groaned, bemoaning pain.
The Man got closer, He got deeper,
To solve the problem- relieve the strain.

Within reach the tree's own heart,
The Keeper saw the core was rotten.
The tree would have to lose its part,
Its previous state to be forgotten.

The Keeper worked with many trees,
And hope was still within His grasp.
The mighty handle He did seize,
The dreaded handle of the ax.

He chopped away the rotten lumber,
Felling the tree, He reached the core.

Ne'er did He let his axing cumber*,
Till He near reached the foliage floor.

And there, the stump and roots lay barren,
No leaves to hide their honest state.
The Keeper, He- the Rose of Sharon*,
Had finally lightened all the rotten weight.

And there, upon the stump He grafted*,
The one true Source of wondrous fruit.
And there beside the tree He crafted,
A cross that did His deed impute.

The tree did let the Source to grow,
And didn't try to make its own.
And whene'er the wind would blow,
It leaned upon the cross alone.

Now did the grafted tree but bring,
Fresh fruit upon its solid branches.
It brought plenty more than leaves in spring,
And now was worth much more than planches*.

The tree could finally feel the freedom,
Not having death as dreaded fate.
The tree was but a shining beacon,
Now standing firm, now standing straight.

And every day, the Rose of Sharon*,
Does lighten down to visit there,
And now the tree, no longer barren,
Illuminates* its Keeper fair.

Planches- French word for boards*

Marred- impaired in appearance, disfigured.*

Hatel- having a sense of enmity toward someone or something.*

Cumber- Verb: to hold back.*

Rose of Sharon- Biblical (allegorical) image of Jesus from the Old Testament.*

Grafted- to insert (a shoot of twig) as a graft. A "graft" is a shoot or twig inserted into a slit on the trunk or stem of a living plant, from which it receives sap.*

Planches- French word for boards*

Illuminates- to light up or make visible by use of light.*

Give Me a Box of Faith

Give me a box of faith.
What is the substance thereof?
In what manner is it made?

Give me a description that I might pursue it,
And find its wondrous annals*, to read of it in full.
Give me the breadth and height thereof,
That I might search it through and through.

Give me a description of its complexion,
That I at least might know its gaze,
If I dare come to see it.

Where can I find this precious gift,
And of what matter is it formed?
By which means is it obtained,
By which means can it be born?

Give me a glass thereof that I might drink its sweetest flow.
Show me, where can I find its springs,
That I might draw thereof and freely glow.

Can knowledge compensate its lack,
Can understanding fill its void?
Can an awareness of its existence
Be enough to bridge the gap
Between one's endless doom and woe,
And somehow bear him heavenward?

Can hopeless scouring to and fro the earth,
Be but enough to gain its acquisition*?
Can endless search by day and night,
Obtain its worth obtaining?

Can man be brought to such a state
Where his sobriety* and will instate
Enough authority in part
To save his weary beating heart,
And from damnation draw him hence?
With works can man gain recompense*?

Is heaven something to be earned?
Is faith a substance to be sought?
Or is its composition and existence
Something that cannot be wrought?

Did we but merit our belief,
Or did our reckless lives in memories past
Deserve our new condition?

Do we yet now deserve,
This state which we do but observe,
Within our faith to safely hold,
Apart from which we would not dare?

Is *faith* a book that can be read?
Is *it* an art that can be learned?
Its coming to the weary heart
Is something solely yearned*-

And yet- it seems that sadly so
It isn't mind or will that sow
This *gift* that is so often spurred*,
By many pondering voices.

For truly *it* is but a gift.
It forms as gently as a mist,
And by the aid of God alone
In weary pilgrim's heart enthroned
It rises by His own benevolence*.
That no man now can boast *its* gain,
That no heart dare in pride proclaim,
That it had somehow played a part
In acquisition hence.

For only in humility,
God visits those who do but plea,
To Him their cry is ever heard
He- being lover of their soul.

And by His love alone we stand,
Now firmer, bolder by His hand,
Not by our own strength rise we now in faith,
But by our sovereign Lord's endowing grace.

Give me a box of *faith* that I might believe,
Or rather, yet- to this conclusion have I finally drawn.
Let me in humility but dwell- in rev'rence of my sovereign Lord.
And let me fin'lly live in peace- knowing, this *gift* is of my God alone.

Amen.

Just to clarify the previous passage, I'm not a Calvinist, but I have to admit that my coming to faith is a gift of God endowed by His grace, and that I couldn't merit or earn it by any means. I don't deserve it. Any faith that I do have, I have it because God had allowed me to grow through circumstances in life to trust and believe in Him. Though I chose to believe, the opportunity to do so was provided by God's grace alone, and I trust that He foresaw my choice and helped form my circumstances that I might believe. If there is still any confusion, look up the difference between synergism and monergism. I think that from our humble every day view of the world, we do and should view the world as a synergetic relationship with God, and yet from a more sober stance, we have to realize the claims of monergism as a fully plausible if not likely. If we do not consider both, we might easily fall into either a work's-based salvation system or a neo-Calvinistic free grace and fatalism position. To understand my position, view Philippians 2:12-13. Proverbs 16:1,9,33 might also be helpful.

Knowledge does not, nor can ever equate to true faith, though it can (by God's grace) lead to it. Understanding the Bible is also found in like manner, my meaning being- that it leads to faith. Reading the Bible doesn't equate to faith, it is only a means to it.

Annals- historical records.*

Acquisition- an asset or object bought or obtained.*

Sobriety- being serious, sensible, and solemn.*

Recompense- an equivalent or a return for something done.*

Yearned- have an intense feeling of longing for something.*

Spurred- give an incentive or encouragement to (someone). To urge.*

Benevolence- the quality of being well meaning; kindness.*

Glory Fair

Even on the cross He saved,
Though was dying, yet He gave-
Hopeless man, to sin a slave
Peace and comfort from the grave.

Even on the cross He served.
Pleasure, comfort, peace- deferred.
Hanging on the cross, impaired.
The fullness of His life He shared.

Even though His blood ran red,
Words of solace still He said.
“Mother, here- this is your son.”
“Father, may Your will be done.”

Hanging on the cross forlorn,
Clothes, all but a garment, torn.
Brought to shame upon a cross.
Made our gain- His very loss.

Came He down upon this earth,
Born of man He made of dearth,
Died to save the sinner’s soul.
Rose to make the broken whole.

Reconciling heaven ‘n man-
Finishing in full God’s plan.
Till this day His power saves
Bringing freedom sinner’s slaves.

Chains no longer hold them down-
Casting forth a glorious crown
Up upon those glassy seas
Bowing down their head and knees.

Fore the throne of God above-
Soaking in the praise thereof.
Will you join me over there
Yonder in that glory fair?

Short Poems

A wanton left wanting in vanity's vice-
A hedonist hopeless- in need of a Christ,
For these He came down and suffered in full,
To make sins of scarlet now whiter than wool.

Wanton- an archaic word for lustful worldly passions or desires. See (James 5:5) KJV for context.

-

Silence is golden- a river of peace
Flowing into tranquility- a gentle release.
Music is beauty, if within the right form,
Tugs at the heart strings of the weary and worn.

-

Drafted to fight a war you never wanted-
Signed up to carry pain you never chose.
Called to bear the burden laid upon you-
Chosen for a cause you do not even know.

Fighting, having lost cause- lost direction.
Fighting- the end ne'er nearing sight.
Fighting- in an endless sea of chaos
Fighting- till the darkness turns to light

Thoughts That Drove this Project

I feel much safer pleading for mercy at the feet of my God then fearing His wrath whilst fleeing His presence. In the one there is hope for forgiveness- the other, an immanence of doom.

To write deeply, you must feel deeply. How can you fully express something you have never truly felt?

“No tears in the writer- no tears in the reader.” – Robert Frost

As time passes, you start to see things differently than you did before. Life begins to have new and deeper meaning that stands in stark contrast to what you could have previously considered or imagined. Every action has immeasurable consequences. Every thought produces its appropriate effect.

If I only knew half of the pain and the struggles other people are going through, I wouldn't be so quick to judge.

What happens when we stop worrying about our own reputations, and we start caring about God's. What would change if what God thinks mattered more to you than other people's opinions?

I'd rather hear one bitter truth than a thousand sweet but deadly lies.

At the end of the day, what you say won't matter as much as what you do.

The more you know, the more you realize that maybe you don't know so much.

If God abode within man, it would be as clear as day. If God's Spirit lives within you- is it visible? Can people tell that you have Christ within you every day?

Does God give us what we want in life, or what we need? Do we pray: “According to our wants,” or, “according to Your will?”

Either desires are subject to their master, or the master is subject to his desires.

Being smart is not the same as being wise. Busyness does not signify impact.

Some of the nicest, kindest people you know have experienced some of the deepest pain that you could ever imagine. That's exactly what has made them so kind- so gentle- so careful not to hurt anybody- because they don't want to put others through what they have experienced.

It usually isn't the people who are good at something that end up in ministry, but rather the people who are willing to do what is needed, even when it causes them discomfort.

Once I'm dead, I'm dead, but let it never be said that I didn't try my best. Salvation is by grace through faith, and yet, we're supposed to fight to be victors. Why did Paul beat his body into submission- to not be disqualified for the prize. Though God works in us both to will and to do of His good pleasure, nobody ever said to stop working out your own salvation with fear and trembling.
(Philippians 2:12-13)

Put as much deep thought into as few words as possible. Don't waste a possibility to make a difference.

Love God, love people, never quit.

I will have more to learn than I ever will have wished to learn by the time I die- but if I wish to be a man, and if I wish to fulfill the will of God in my life, I will go at it head first and will trust God to be my guide in all of it.

If you have lived for Christ with all your might, what fear should you ever have to also die for Him.

The concept of free will being a prerequisite of love, and the origin of pain hails (as best I can tell) from C. S. Lewis's "God's in the Dock."

Jesus Christ Came to Save Sinners

If that sounds familiar, it's the title of a book by Spurgeon (trust me- I am very original.)

I'll be paraphrasing the passage Matthew 9:10-12. So basically, Jesus is having dinner with a bunch of bottom of the barrel, average, every day, ordinary sinners, and the Pharisees come up, and they ask Jesus's disciples- pause for a second, notice that they don't ask Him. Either they're too afraid to ask Him, or they're just disrespecting Him right in front of His face by speaking indirectly about Him. Resume- anyways, they ask His disciples something along the lines of "Why is **He** -Jesus- eating with **them**- sinners." And notice what Jesus says in verse twelve. This is Matthew 9:12 NKJV. He says, "Those who are well have no need of a physician, but those who are sick."

Healthy people don't need doctors. It's the sick people who need doctors. These sick people- they need a doctor the *most*.

Those who are sick. Underline that in your Bible. You won't get struck by lightning for doing it- trust me. Just underline those words.

I- a sinner, I- who am broken, I- who am sick, am most in need of a Saviour. I- am most in need of Christ.

It's easy to forget that *I'm* the sinner in this picture. It's easy to forget that *I* need Christ every single day of my life. When was the last time I realized that I truly need Christ? I need Him. *I* am that sick person.

John 15:5 NKJV Jesus says, "I am the vine, you are the branches. He who abides in Me, and I in him, bears much fruit; for without Me you can do nothing." I want you to underline that word. Nothing.

Question- how far can a branch be separated from a tree and still bring fruit. Can it be two inches- maybe one? How far can I be away from Christ while still bearing fruit. It's impossible. If you cut a branch from a tree, it's going to start dying. Try to save it. Put it in some water- I don't know.

As soon as a branch is disconnected from the tree, it starts to die. As soon as I- am disconnected from Christ- I start to die.

Somebody once put it this way, "Jesus Christ didn't come to make bad men good. He came to make dead men live."

In John 10:10, Jesus says, "I have come that they may have life, and that they may have it more abundantly." He gave up his life so that those who follow Him, His sheep, might have the fullness thereof.

The purpose of His ministry was not to fix *my* attitude or *my* ego. It wasn't to change how I dress. It's much deeper than that. He came to give me life. To change what's inside- my heart. Of course, those things will happen. Lives change. My outer life changed, but that's just a side effect of having a relationship with God. It wasn't the purpose of His ministry. It wasn't the main goal of His life. We deserved death, but Jesus Christ came to bring us life, and life abundantly. He came to restore our shattered, fragmented relationship with God.

When you woke up this morning, how many of you thought: "I need Christ today, more than ever before"?

You know, the fact that I woke up today, and I may have not even gotten to spend more than- I don't know- 10 or 15 minutes with **Him** in prayer, like- that scares me. I want to be able to be like Paul and say that "I have resolved to know nothing while I was with you except Jesus Christ and him crucified." I want to be able to say that "I consider all things loss for the excellency of the knowledge of Christ Jesus my LORD." I want to be able to say that "I consider all things as dung that I might win Christ."

I want to be able to not care about what anyone thinks, and only care about what Jesus Christ-what God thinks of me. I want to be a man after God's own heart -like David- but just like David, I fail- a lot. I'm broken. I need Christ.

I don't want my life to be mine anymore. I want to live by the saying, "He died for me, and now I live for Him." I *need* Him- I need Him a lot more than I might even realize. I'm sure we all have that feeling. It's just that- we forget about it sometimes. We lose that fire for Christ. We lose that razor focus, and we become lukewarm. Tepid.

I don't think we, as self-respecting people, like to imagine ourselves as sick or as sinful. We don't like to think that "we're the problem." We like to think that we're the heroes, that we're great, that we're popular, and you know- I don't think that there's anything inherently wrong with wanting or aspiring to be better, but it can become one of our biggest weaknesses.

We don't like to admit that we're failures. We don't like to admit that we're flawed. That we're imperfect. That we don't match up. I don't know about you guys, but I know that I have my own weaknesses- or flaws. More than I'd like to admit to. But honestly, I don't think anybody wakes up in the morning with the goal to be a bad guy or "the villain." It just happens sometimes. We grow careless and get lost in the mess we're in. At the end of the day, however, I think it's important to know our own flaws and weaknesses- the things we need to work on.

I think that- when we realize our flaws, when we recognize our failures- our imperfections, and finally see ourselves for what we are- only then do we start to comprehend our deep-seeded

need for a Saviour. You can only start to truly appreciate medicine when you've finally started to feel the effects of your own sickness or malady. You're not going to walk around everyday thinking: "Tylenol is the most amazing thing in the world," until you've had a terrible fever, or- a broken bone, or a bad headache. In the same way, we can only start to appreciate God's sacrifice and His love for us, when we start to feel the effects of our own sinfulness, how it eats us up inside, and how it corrupts our souls. How it ruins our lives. Only then can we start to cherish God's love for us and what He has done for us.

We as sinful human beings can't save ourselves. There's a saying for that, and it describes this concept perfectly. You can't pull yourself up to heaven by your own bootstraps. You know- pulling your shoelaces won't lift you up off the ground. Our works, no matter how good they are can't save us. No matter how hard you pull on your shoelaces, you're not going to start floating. Your feet will turn blue before that happens. Without Jesus, we're goners.

If we don't realize that we're the sick people, the end result might show us that we were Pharisees in the story, condemning anything that was below our "standards." If we don't realize our unworthiness and how unholy we are by ourselves, we can easily shroud ourselves with a fake worthiness- a facade of holiness, and that's not going to stand before God on judgement day. You don't take that shroud up with you when you go up to the judgement seat. Our own "self-righteousness" is as filthy rags before a holy, worthy, and just God.

It's easy to forget our need in Jesus. It's easy to forget that we need *His* life in order to live. We need His help to pull through. We need Him- because He is everything. He is everything that is ever worth pursuing in this life, and if I don't love Him with all my heart -that's the first commandment- and if I don't love every single person as much as I do myself -that's the second-; if I'm not doing just that, then I'm missing out on the most important thing that was ever worth doing in this life.

"Jesus Christ came to save sinners, of whom I am the first." as Paul says in 1 Timothy 1:15b. Of whom *I* am the first.

The Battlefield

Our children- the work of our very hands, and yet, not of our own but of God's. I am thoroughly convinced that the greatest sinners are not the prostitutes or drug dealers, but rather those who willingly and knowingly intoxicate the minds of the younger generation with lies and vanity, and who brainwash them in order to destroy their ability to think. These people are the ones who impact our nation the most, and they will be judged accordingly. Likewise, I see it as my (and every single Christian's) calling to positively impact their lives and minds, and to teach them how to think and not what to think. I believe it should be our main focus to raise the next generation the "right way", or else the "wrong way" will inevitably occur.

The question that I think should be plaguing each and every one of our minds is "How do you prepare your child for the next 60 or 70 years of their life and do it in a way that they won't fail, or won't walk away from the faith?" First and foremost, I think that it is abundantly clear that you should trust God with every step you take, because only He is truly capable of leading them in such a way to believe in Him. It isn't our prayers or hard work, but God who saves. Our prayers effect change in this present life, but it is only God who saves each and every soul, and He is the only one who knows how to do it best. Secondly, I think that our bounden duty to do the best that we possibly can as Christians, as the sons of God, to represent and to exemplify God in this world. This is done in the many ways that we personally live and teach our children to live.

And so, to begin, I am thoroughly convinced that we need to teach the younger generation how to think and not what to think. Otherwise, as soon as someone else tells them that they need to think something else, what will stop them from doing so? If we don't teach them how to think, it will most certainly not be their brains. This all needs to happen with prayer for the younger generation, because the strongest we will ever be is when God is aiding us in our cause. Moreover, we must teach them truth, and Biblical morals. Just don't forget to provide as much evidence or proof possible along with this truth (in my opinion). Do we expect them to just mindlessly swallow everything we tell them (even if it is true), and if so, then what will stop them from mindlessly swallowing everything else the world provides? The fact that it is not true? How shall they ever know the difference? Even if faith was ever blind (and I believe it never was), knowledge is not, and neither is truth. Pray for them and give them a reason to believe. Don't just sit there expecting them listen and obey because that's exactly how you lose them. There is now and every single moment a war going on for each and every heart and soul, and do you think that the devil is not constantly waging war for every single child's heart and mind? Is he not constantly waging war on our own's? So how then do you expect him to be standing idly by as we armor and equip his future prey?

Lastly, I want to focus on how we treat the younger generation- the future torchbearers, the ones that will continue our ministry, the ones that will carry on the work that we will inevitably leave behind. Will we be their biggest allies, or will we be their biggest enemies without even realizing it?

Tell me, if you raise up a child believing that he is going to be the biggest failure ever, and tell him that he can't make a difference, what do you think he is going to end up believing? What do you think he will ever attempt in his lifetime without constantly fearing failure? He will quickly find

someone else who believe in him, rather than you, and you will have no control over whether his influence will be bad or good.

Tell me instead, what if you raised up a child, believing in them, and believing that they're going to make a difference. What if you believed that every single child could change thousands of lives in the duration of their lifetime? What if you believed that their prayers make a difference? What if you believed that their faith, though it may not move mountains, can move the heart of a nation? Tell me, what do you think this child will attempt, knowing, that though he might fail, there is still someone who believes in him that much?

As earthly parents, we exemplify to our kids a kind of portrait of what God is like. As instructors and friends of them, we represent Jesus in this world. It is our foremost responsibility to show them Christ. What kind of Christian do you think the children in your life will actually be drawn to; one who believes that everything they do will inevitably fail, or one who believes that even though everything they do fails, they are still loved and cherished in the sight of God? In which one will they actually see Christ? Which one actually resembles who Christ actually was?

The Opioid of Nations

Carl Marx once said that religion is the opioid of the nations. I'd like for you to think about what that means. An opioid is a drug which helps its user ignore reality or alleviate the pain that reality causes. Or- it could be used simply because it brings pleasure. Using that train of thought, many other implications can be derived. We can now call anything that is pleasurable or that helps us ignore or cope with reality an opioid. Entertainment is perhaps a bigger opioid than religion. Sex is an opioid. Spending time with family is an opioid. Anything that alleviates pain or helps us cope with reality is an opioid (if we are to follow Carl Marx's logic.) Saying that religion is an opioid doesn't, in fact, mean anything at all then. It doesn't signify a truth value. Yes, religion helps people deal with pain, but that is not a reason to disbelieve its credibility. If that was the case, I could then continue to defraud every single pleasure or comforting activity that exists by simply stating that it is an opioid. It's the straw-man fallacy. Anybody can do that when they don't want to actually argue about or debate the truth value and the content of something. Another meaning that can be derived from the statement is that religion is used to control others by diverting their attention from reality, or by indirectly controlling what others believe through the use of religion. The same could be said about the media, social networks, politics, entertainment, etc. Again, this does not deal with a truth value. Religion is being swept away and not dealt with upon the basis of its truthfulness or falsity.

Saying that religion soothes wounds, or that it is used to direct people into some form of belief or structure isn't a reason to disbelieve it. Perhaps, it might even be a reason to, on the contrary, adopt some form of religion. People psychologically need structures and stability to function. It's how we're built, and if we are built to have structure, there must, in my opinion, be a reason behind it.

And here we deal with the concept of religion. Religion isn't an opioid of the nations, but rather, it is the legitimate seeking of answers to the questions posed by the broken state of mankind, the seeking of origin or purpose, and the seeking of what is to come after our existence in this world comes to an end. There might be other definitions for religion, but that is not the point. The point is that we have now introduced the concept that religion is a search for truth.

Other definitions of religion could be formed by people examining religion, and not by truly interacting with religion, and thus, these other definitions might be helpful, but they are not truly defining what a party is experiencing when he is within the religion itself. A psychologist or physiologist can examine and define what love is or what effects it has on the human body, but he does not have to experience it to do so. The person who actually experiences love is in fact providing the original definition for what love truly is. What I mean by that is that love would not exist if nobody was ever there to feel it. You could not break it down psychologically or physiologically if nobody ever experienced it. And so, its definition is more clearly established by one who is within it and is not examining it from the outside. The examiner simply provides the context for it, and not the definition.

Another reason that the definition of a physiologist or psychologist cannot be used to refute the truthfulness or falsity of an argument is based on the grounds that they might try to overturn or deny the rationality of something because they know it is just based off a mix of chemical compounds inside of our brain or body that cause those thoughts or feelings. Using this argumentation, one can then continue to overturn what the psychologist or physiologist does while examining something by saying that they are just experiencing a change or mix in chemical reactions. Thus, their examinations have lost all rationality because they have come through natural thought processes inside of the brain. We both know that that is wholly irrational. Why then is this same line of reasoning used to discredit religion? You see, it might be relevant information in discussing religion, but it has no grounds to discredit religion, or to sweep it under the rug. We are still not dealing with the truthfulness or falsity of religion, and that is where the core of the argument lies. (This line of argumentation stems from C. S. Lewis's "Meditations in a Toolshed.")

This all being considered, we could continue to debate for hours over which religion (if any) is true, but the fact that we long for something greater and grander than ourselves (for the existence of such a feeling seems to some extent existent in everybody when they seek to live or exist with purpose, and not without it) points towards something much deeper than our physical condition (from a materialist viewpoint) can provide an answer to. From a materialistic point of view, why should we exist if not to seek pleasure and to propagate in some form or another in order to preserve our species.

I am aware that there is the understanding that the march of progress is inevitable because evolution seeks to continue its creative process and create newer and more advanced creatures, but now you have applied a creative and progress-centered force to evolution. It now has a purpose and a goal and is no longer an inanimate force if it has a will. You've essentially created a god of your own while trying to ignore or refute the existence of one. One now has to believe in evolution in a very similar way that he would have had to belief in God. Taking into account that the probability of life on earth existing as it has to have the extremely low probability of 1 in 10^{1040} , the modern atheist has a lot of faith in "evolution" and the process of disorder converting itself into order.

Now if your purpose was to create or discover a new god to divert people's attention from the preexisting One or ones, or even if you have any other logical reason for doing so, you have essentially succeeded, but now you have but only entered the arena of theological debate and would have to defend your beliefs. You have not established a preeminence of truth because your beliefs have spawned upon the ground of what some call "science" (because this "science" is purely theoretical and not empirical when it comes to major evolution as opposed to minor evolution). All belief systems are equal and must be allowed to endure criticism and debate- especially when these belief systems affect how billions of lives are lived and how billions more are discredited or completely eradicated.

I may have lost some of my readers here, and so I shall explain. I was postulating that science is a belief system in and of itself, and that it relies in a belief that evolution has a will or a driving life force to achieve progress. This has a purposeful existence concentrated about a specific goal, and that establishes it as a being at least somewhat equivalent to what we call a god. How

come existence has a purpose and not a meaningless nothing? How have we ascribed purpose to a meaningless concept? In short, science does not rid you of the argument of religion, but rather more deeply enthralls you into it. Thus, it is wholly irrational for those who believe in evolution to discredit any religion upon the grounds that it has a God or gods which have a purpose or a driving force to them. This is because they themselves believe in something that holds an equal purpose as a God (or gods) would. Science has ascribed to evolution the purpose that religion has ascribed to God.

But enough on that. I realize that when considering the pursuit of purpose, the argument of a strong nihilist versus a weak nihilist also exists, but I honestly do not find it very convincing, and if I do consider it as a rational argument in the future, I would like to understand it better before I attempt to refute it. I've tried to chase every rabbit, turn every stone, and kick every dead horse along the way, but considering the subject matter- you wouldn't want to bet your life on something without fully exploring it. This being the case, I like to be thorough. As a refresher, we have started to consider religions as a whole, and I have tried to give an explanation for why the materialistic perspective is irrational as a complete refutation of religion, and that it by itself should be considered, in one form or another, a religion.

Realizing our broken condition, we're left with a world where we can either find an answer to our questions or we can't, but our longing for one is a legitimate fact that I think needs to be addressed. Why would a need for perfection or justice be something that would rise from a natural world? Could a longing after imperfection or injustice not do just as well if it led to the same end result? How come morality has become the vehicle for successful societies as opposed to immorality? How come mercy, fairness, equality, and justice are such a pertinent societal construct, that any society without them ceases to exist? Many scientist stress the fact that all of the above are necessary factors in precluding successful societies, but they never question why. Again, they ascribe their model of evolution with traits that seem awfully similar to religion without ever explaining why these traits are inherently necessary. They never explain why.

Something else to consider is that if we don't address the issues, we won't be able to properly access the situation. The question we all have to deal with is "Why is a miserable something better than nothing at all?" because we all know that something exists rather than nothing, and we know that something just isn't right the way that it is. This "just isn't right feeling" is why we have struggles- why we have wars. We do not have peace. We are not content with the current state of being. Thus, realizing that we exist, and that we have problems, we have to find a reason or an explanation for why we feel this way and in a best-case scenario- a way to cope with our problems. The above boil down to the need for answers that are not skin deep, and that these answers have to give credible grounds for the existence of a longing for something better.

Upon further questioning you might be left with a few options of what one would do after considering all the above. Two important ones which would probably pop up in your head would be "Which "religion" aligns most to reality when we look at it historically, archeologically, scientifically, psychologically, philosophically, etc.?" or, you could take the route of Thomas Jefferson and ask something along the lines of "A tool is only measured by its benefits and the end